

# Google Business Profile Checklist

A practical, policy-aware checklist for setting up, reviewing, and maintaining a Business Profile on Google. This checklist is written to match current Google guidance as of September 2026.

**Important before you begin:** A Google Business Profile is for eligible businesses that make in-person contact with customers during stated hours, with limited exceptions. Online-only businesses are not eligible. Features and available fields can vary by business category, country, device, and account.

## 1. Confirm the business is eligible

Do this first. A perfectly completed profile is still the wrong tool if the business does not meet Google's eligibility rules.

[ ] Confirm the business makes in-person contact with customers during its stated hours, either at a customer-facing location or by traveling to customers.

[ ] Confirm the business is not an online-only business, lead-generation company, rental-only property, or other ineligible entity.

[ ] Confirm the person managing the profile is the business owner or an authorized representative.

[ ] Use one profile for the business location unless Google's location, department, practitioner, or brand rules provide a specific exception.

[ ] If a marketing agency is involved, make sure the business owner understands the profile, retains ownership, and knows what actions the agency will take.

**Why this matters: eligibility and ownership errors can lead to verification problems, edits being rejected, or profile restrictions. Do not treat eligibility as a technical SEO exercise; it is a policy requirement.**

## 2. Business name: use the real-world name

Google is unusually specific here: the profile name should reflect the business as it is represented and recognized in the real world.

[ ] Use the actual business name used consistently on the storefront, website, stationery, and customer-facing materials.

[ ] Do not add service keywords, city names, taglines, hours, phone numbers, URLs, or promotional language to the name just to make the listing more searchable.

[ ] If the legal entity name includes an LLC, Inc., or similar term, use it only when that element is genuinely part of the real-world business name and you can support the representation.

[ ] For multi-location businesses, keep names consistent unless Google's documented exceptions apply.

**Simple test:** If the words would not normally appear in the business name on the business's own signage, website, invoices, or other real-world materials, pause before adding them to the profile name.

## 3. Address, storefront, service area, or hybrid setup

Choose the business model that matches reality. The address decision is not a marketing preference; it is a representation of where and how the business operates.

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- [ ] Storefront: use the real-world business address and make sure the location is customer-facing and properly represented.
  - [ ] Service-area business: if customers are not served at the business address, hide the address and specify the areas actually served.
  - [ ] Hybrid: keep the physical location and define the service area when customers are served both at the location and elsewhere.
  - [ ] Never use a virtual office or remote mailbox as a substitute for an actual operating location where Google requires one.
  - [ ] For service areas, enter actual cities, postal codes, or other supported areas. Google currently allows up to 20 service areas and says the overall area should generally not extend beyond about two hours of driving from the business base.
  - [ ] Check that the map pin, suite/unit details, and public address match the real-world location.
  - [ ] If the address is displayed to customers, verify that the business maintains permanent fixed signage consistent with the business name.

## 4. Website, phone, and core contact information

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- [ ] Use the business's authoritative website for the location represented by the profile.
- [ ] Use a phone number under the direct control of the business. Use a local number when practical.
- [ ] Avoid redirecting customers to a different business, unrelated landing page, or someone else's phone number.
- [ ] Open the website link from the live profile and confirm it loads over HTTPS and reaches the correct business.
- [ ] Confirm the website contact information agrees with what customers see elsewhere.

## 5. Hours and special hours

Hours are customer information, not filler.

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- [ ] Enter normal customer-facing hours that reflect when customers can actually interact with the business.
- [ ] Do not invent hours for a business that operates only by appointment or whose industry is specifically treated differently by Google.
- [ ] Use Special hours for holidays, special events, temporary changes, or exceptional closures.
- [ ] Use additional or service-specific hours only when they are available and genuinely useful for the business.
- [ ] Check holiday dates before major holidays and verify that temporary changes do not accidentally overwrite regular hours.

## 6. Primary and additional categories

Category selection is about what the business is, not every service or feature it happens to have.

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- [ ] Choose the most specific available primary category that accurately represents the core business.
- [ ] Use as few categories as necessary to describe the overall business.
- [ ] Do not select categories solely because they contain useful keywords.

[ ] Do not add categories for products, amenities, nearby businesses, or related entities unless those categories genuinely describe the business.

[ ] Use the "This business IS a..." test when choosing categories.

[ ] Review category choices when the business model changes, but remember that editing a category can trigger another verification review.

## 7. Business description

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[ ] Explain what the business offers and what makes it useful to customers.

[ ] Use a clear, natural description rather than a keyword list.

[ ] Keep the description within Google's 750-character limit.

[ ] Do not put URLs, HTML, prices, sales, or promotion-focused content in the description field.

[ ] Make sure the description is factually accurate and written for the customer who is deciding whether to contact the business.

## 8. Services, attributes, and other profile details

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[ ] Add the services the business actually provides and group them logically when the editor allows categories.

[ ] Use service descriptions to clarify what the service is; avoid stuffing phone numbers, irrelevant text, or prohibited promotional content into custom service names.

[ ] Add factual attributes that apply to the business. Attribute availability varies by category and region.

[ ] For eligible retail businesses, review product features and product data when available.

[ ] For businesses with supported action links, make sure appointment, reservation, ordering, or other transaction links go to the correct customer action.

## 9. Photos and video

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[ ] Verify the profile before expecting photos and videos to appear publicly.

[ ] Use original, accurate, well-lit imagery that represents the actual business, products, or services.

[ ] Use relevant category-specific photos rather than a generic collection of stock images.

[ ] Check that photos are in focus and not heavily altered or covered with excessive filters.

[ ] Periodically replace outdated images when the storefront, team, product presentation, or service environment changes.

## 10. Reviews and reputation management

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The goal is genuine customer feedback, not a manufactured rating.

[ ] Ask real customers for honest reviews after genuine interactions.

[ ] Do not pay for reviews or offer discounts, goods, or services in exchange for a review, revision, or removal.

[ ] Do not selectively pressure customers to leave positive reviews or dictate the wording they should use.

[ ] Respond to reviews professionally and factually, especially when a customer raises a real service issue.

☐ Document clearly suspicious or policy-violating review activity before using Google's reporting process.

## 11. Posts and updates

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☐ Use posts for useful, relevant information rather than repetitive promotional filler.

☐ Review text for spelling, clarity, and accuracy before publishing.

☐ Use only trusted URLs and avoid prohibited content.

☐ Do not assume a post is live immediately; Google may review content and show statuses such as Live, Pending, or Not approved.

☐ Update posts when the underlying event, offer, or information changes.

## 12. Social links and connected actions

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☐ Where the feature is available, add one link per supported social platform that genuinely represents the business.

☐ Check the destination URL for broken, duplicated, invalid, or unsupported links.

☐ Remember that social links are available only in select regions and Google may also add or source some links automatically.

☐ Do not rely on social links as a substitute for the authoritative business website.

## 13. Final review before calling the profile complete

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☐ Business is eligible under current Google guidelines.

☐ Owner/authorized representative controls the profile.

☐ Business name matches the real-world name.

☐ Address/service area matches actual operations.

☐ Website and phone are authoritative and functional.

☐ Hours and special hours are accurate.

☐ Primary category is specific and representative.

☐ Description is useful, factual, and within 750 characters.

☐ Services and attributes are accurate.

☐ Photos represent the real business and are current.

☐ Review solicitation and responses follow Google policy.

☐ Posts and links are accurate and functional.

☐ Profile has been checked on both Search and Maps where practical.

☐ Changes have been documented so future edits can be traced.

**What this checklist does not promise:** Completing every item does not guarantee a particular local ranking. Google says local results are mainly based on relevance, distance, and prominence, and the exact ranking systems are not published in full. The practical goal is an accurate, eligible, useful profile that gives Google and customers reliable information.

# Current reference sources

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**Google Business Profile Help - Guidelines for representing your business on Google**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/3038177>

**Google Business Profile Help - Business eligibility and ownership**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/13763036>

**Google Business Profile Help - Manage service areas**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/9157481>

**Google Business Profile Help - Manage your business address**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/2853879>

**Google Business Profile Help - Manage categories**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/7249669>

**Google Business Profile Help - Manage services**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/9455399>

**Google Business Profile Help - Manage photos and videos**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/6103862>

**Google Business Profile Help - Manage local business links**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/6218037>

**Google Business Profile Help - Local ranking guidance**

<https://support.google.com/business/answer/7091>

**Google Maps User-Generated Content Policy - Fake engagement and reviews**

<https://support.google.com/contributionpolicy/answer/7400114>

Prepared September 24, 2026. Google may change product features or policies after publication; check the linked documentation before making a compliance-sensitive change.